

Expectations and Moments

August 19, 2026

Expectations and moments

The probability distribution defines weighted averages over the sample space, where the weight of each event is equal to its probability. These are called *expected values*.

Discrete case

For the discrete case,

$$\mathbb{E}[f(X)] = \sum_{k=1}^n f(x_k) p(x_k).$$

Continuous case

While for the continuous case,

$$\mathbb{E}[f] = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) p(x) dx.$$

Mean of a distribution

The mean of the distribution is the expectation of the random variable itself. We denote

$$\mu \equiv \mathbb{E}[X] = \overline{X} = \langle X \rangle = \begin{cases} \sum x_k p(x_k), & \text{(discrete)} \\ \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x p(x) dx, & \text{(continuous)} \end{cases}$$

In the case of an infinite sample space, whether continuous or discrete, the mean is not guaranteed to exist since the integral or the sum might not converge.

Moments of a distribution

The moments of a distribution are the expectation of powers of the random variable itself.

$$\mu_\ell \equiv \mathbb{E}[X^\ell] \equiv \langle X^\ell \rangle = \begin{cases} \sum x_k^\ell p(x_k), & (\text{discrete}) \\ \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x^\ell p(x) dx, & (\text{continuous}) \end{cases}$$

If all the moments are known – and if they exist – they can be used to get the expectation of other functions using the **linearity** of the expectation operator:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[c f(X)] &= c \mathbb{E}[f(X)], \\ \mathbb{E}[f(X) + g(X)] &= \mathbb{E}[f(X)] + \mathbb{E}[g(X)] \end{aligned}$$

Variance and standard deviation

Of particular interest is the second moment, in combination with the mean, defining the **variance**

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma^2 = \text{Var}(X) &\equiv \mathbb{E}[(X - \mu)^2] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2 - 2\mu X + \mu^2] \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - 2\mu \mathbb{E}[X] + \mu^2 \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mu^2 \\ &= \mathbb{E}[X^2] - \mathbb{E}[X]^2 \end{aligned}$$

Higher moments characterize properties of a distribution

Variance – dispersion measure based on the second moment:

$$\sigma^2 = \mathbb{E}[(X - \mu)^2] = \int (x - \mu)^2 p(x) dx$$

Skewness – asymmetry parameter based on third moments; dimensionless (normalized cumulant):

$$s \equiv \frac{\mathbb{E}[(X - \mu)^3]}{\sigma^3} = \mathbb{E}\left[\left(\frac{X - \mu}{\sigma}\right)^3\right]$$

Kurtosis – measure of tail "weights" in terms of fourth moments; zero for a Gaussian (excess kurtosis), bounded below by -1:

$$\kappa \equiv \frac{\mathbb{E}[(X - \mu)^4]}{\sigma^4} - 3$$

Covariance and correlation

For any two random variables, not necessarily independent or identically distributed, their covariance is defined as:

$$\text{Cov}(X, Y) \equiv \mathbb{E}[(X - \mu_x)(Y - \mu_y)] = \mathbb{E}[XY] - \mu_x \mu_y$$

The correlation is proportional to the covariance,

$$\rho(X, Y) = \text{Corr}(X, Y) \equiv \frac{\text{Cov}(X, Y)}{\sqrt{\text{Var}(X) \text{Var}(Y)}} = \mathbb{E} \left[\left(\frac{X - \mu_x}{\sigma_x} \right) \left(\frac{Y - \mu_y}{\sigma_y} \right) \right]$$

Dividing the covariance by the standard deviations makes the correlation a pure number, and

$$-1 \leq \rho(X, Y) \leq +1$$